



MENTAL MODELS · 05

The Constraint Box

Map what a tool was built for before mapping what you hope it can do.



Every AI tool has a box it was
built for.



The failures that matter are almost always someone using it outside that box.



A model trained for conversational fluency isn't automatically good at arithmetic.



A summarizer isn't automatically a fact-checker. A code assistant trained on public repos doesn't automatically know your internal conventions.



Before adopting any AI tool, map its actual constraint box — what it was optimized for.



**...before mapping what you hope it
can do.**

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